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summarize the author's engagement with the theories of frances yates and his discussion of hypnerotomachia polyphili

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This w i l l to
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medical matters of the period, subse-
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A th i rd trend, as meek and obscure as the others were famous and persistent, almost passed unobserved or was close to being assimilated by the two others. Indeed, there can exist phantasms unrelated to a real object, but, thanks to the qual i ty of their images, there can be no phan-



FIGURE 2. Bacchanalian revels. From Francesco Colonna, Discours du Songe de Poliphile [Hypnerotomachia] (Paris, 1554). Courtesy of the Wing Foundation, The
Newberry Library, Chicago.

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The contents of the Hypnerotomachia tally with the date 1467. Indeed, the work is external to the current of ideas circulated by Marsilio Ficino



FIGURE 3. ″Two wretched damsels, naked and disheveled.″ From Francesco Colonna, Discours du Songe de Poliphile [Hypnerotomachia] (Paris, 1554). Courtesy of the Wing Foundation, The Newberry Library, Chicago.

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beginning more or less in 1463.41 From our point of v iew, the fact that i t escapes Ficino's influence is invaluable. Even when expressing a person-
al point of v iew on love, wh ich rarely happens, Pico della Mirandola, Pietro Bembo, Baldesar Castiglione, Leo the Hebrew, and Melanchthon bear the indelible mark of Ficino's thought. O n the contrary, Colonna (though he, too, treats of the phantasmic Eros) is original and inimitable,
less in his ideas—a common heritage of the period, of wh ich Ficino is to become the systematic organizer—than in the l i terary and didactic quali-
ty of his work.

(iv) Phantasms at Work

Let us make the acquaintance of phantasms.
Taken literally, the title

Hypnerotomachia means a " love f ight dur ing

sleep." This leads us to expect that a person dreams of phantasms in-
volved in an erotic f ight, perhaps his o w n erotic phantasm. That is pre-
cisely what happens: two phantasms, that of the dreamer—Pol iphi lus—
and that of the gir l he loves—Polia—are at the center of the scenario.

The tale is not constructed so as to be easily understood. It is an enigma



whose solution is given only at the end. The reader is informed that
Poliphilus seeks Polia, but does not know w h y or how. Of the 311 pages
of the Guegan-Kerver edition, the first part takes up 250 whereas the
second, which provides indispensable explanations, takes up only 60.

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Content Snippet:
Yates's undeniable merit is to have integrated Bruno's oeuvre into its cultural context; for the first time in the history of modern philosophy, Bruno was not envisaged as the clumsy, grotesque, and "bacchanalian" precursor of
modern thinking but as one of the most impressive representatives of Renais-sance thought. It is, fundamentally, a question of applying different categories

Notes to Pages 91-113 236 236

and of measuring h im by the standards of another era, and historians of ideas can never be sufficiently grateful to Yates for having patiently explained the difference. That does not prevent her f rom labeling as ″Hermeticism″ all sorts of
doctrines of Late Ant iqu i ty of which Hermeticism d id indeed make use but wh ich d id not have a ″Hermet ic″ origin. The quotations in the text and in the
footnotes conform to the editions of Bruno's works mentioned at the beginning of this footnote. The passage concerning the interrogation of May 30, 1592, is reproduced by Gentile, I I , p. 211, no. 1.

33. These biographical data are indisputable. They are to be found in nearly
all the works cited in n. 32 above.

34. J.-R. Charbonnel, L'Ethique de Giordano Bruno et le deuxième dialogue du Spac-
cio . . . Contribution à l'étude des

conceptions morales de la Renaissance (Paris, 1919), p. 35.

35. Ibid., p. 276.
36. Henninger, p. 44.
37. See Keller's observation in Le Soleil à la Renaissance, pp. 63-64. On Digges's infinite empyrean heaven—an idea that was, at bottom, merely traditional—see also Debus, pp. 87-88.

38. Cf. Keith Thomas, Religion and the Decline of Magic, (Harmondsworth [1971], 1978), p. 412. On John Dee in general, see Peter J. French, John Dee: The World of an Elizabethan Magus (London, 1972).

39. Op. it., I, p. 21.
40. Ibid.; cf. De docta ignorantia, II, pp. 11-12.
41. Op. cit., I, p. 92.
42. P. Ramus, De religione Christiana, Frankfurt ed., (1577), pp. 114-15, cited

by Yates, The Art of Memory, p. 237.

43. Yates, ibid., pp. 234-35.

44. Ibid., p. 237.

45. Ibid., p. 261.

46. See n. 38 above.

47. Yates, The Art of Memory, pp. 266 sq.

48. Quoted by Yates, ibid., p. 278.

49. G. Perkins Cantabrigensis, Antidicsonus (London, 1584), p. 45, quoted by Yates, pp. 274-75. Fundamentally, Perkins was more correct than Yates thinks; it is true that with respect to Peter of Ravenna an absolutely inoffensive practice is at issue (he believes the image of an old love is particularly suited to being recorded by the memory, due to its emotional charge).

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whose solution is given only at the end. The reader is informed that Poliphilus seeks Polia, but does not know w h y or how. Of the 311 pages of the Guegan-Kerver edition, the first part takes up 250 whereas the second, which provides indispensable explanations, takes up only 60. The first part tells of the endless roaming of Poliphilus amid the ruins of antiquity, of tr iumphs, emblems and impresae, each w i th its own secret meaning. As Yates observed, it could be a matter of mnemotechnics escaped f″ rom control and degenerated into w i l d imaginings.42″ In any case, such oneirico-archeologico-mnemotechnics, however fascinating, w i l l not preoccupy us here. In the end, Poliphilus finds Polia, and the lovers plead their case before the heavenly tr ibunal of Venus. The sec-ond part, wh ich contains two

monologues, is therefore a tale within a tale,
and the end is destined to complicate the enigma still more: we learn that everything that happened was only Poliphilus's dream, so that the search for Polia and the appeasement of desire were but adventures in phantasy.43

Neither mystical love nor vulgar love, Poliphilus's dream represents the trite story of phantasmic desire that finds fulf i l lment.

The tale is saved f rom platitude and indecency by its phantasmic quality: desire, provoked by a phantasm, is appeased by the phantasm, after a period of erotico-mnemotechnic tribulations.

(v) The Depth Psychology of Ficino

D E S C E N T OF T H E SOUL

Souls descend into the bodies of the Mi lky Way through the constellation of Cancer, enveloping themselves in a celestial and luminous veil which they put on to

enter terrestrial
bodies. For nature demands that the very
pure soul be united
w i th the very impure body only through
the intermediary of a
pure veil, which, being less pure than
the soul and purer than
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nient means of uni t ing the soul w i th
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due to that descent that the souls and
bodies of the Planets
confirm and reinforce, i n our Souls and
our bodies respec-
tively, the seven original gifts
bestowed upon us by God. The
same function is performed by the
[seven] categories of de-
mons, intermediaries between the
celestial gods and men. The
gift of contemplation is strengthened by
Saturn by means of
the Saturnian Demons.

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For all parties, the prel iminaries of desire consist i n setting u p a phantasm w i t h i n the subject. For some,
this phantasm w i l l have the capacity to awaken their allayed desire, to propel and accompany them on their t r ip th rough the intel l igential cos-
mos. This w i l l become a heroic passion ending in an ecstatic fusion of the hunter and the object of his hunt—
accord ing to an image employed
by Ficino and later revived by Giordano Bruno. For others, the phan-

tasm w i l l only point to a painfu l
and urgent need for a physical release
which increases in propor t ion as its
fu l f i l lment is postponed.

In this case there w i l l be a
fundamental contradict ion between the
medical concept of a phantasmic Eros
that disturbs the equi l ibr ium of
the organism and demands p rompt
assuagement to restore this equi-
l ibr ium, and the concept of the " fa i
th fu l , -a complete denial of the for
"
mer, f ind ing expression through a
semantic inversion valor iz ing the
disequil ibr ium in terms of a plenary
spir i tual experience. This w i l l to
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medical matters of the period, subse-
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35. Wind attributes them to Nicholas of Cusa's disciple John Andreas of Bussi.

36. On the Orphic myth, see W. K. C. Guthrie, Orphaeus and Greek Religion, 2d ed. (London, 1952); H. Jeanmaire, Dionysos: Histoire du culte de Bacchus (Paris,
Payot, 1950).

37. Heraclitus, fr. 52. On the "Orphic" interpretation of this fragment, see V. Macchioro, Eraclito, nuovi studi sull' Orßsmo (Bari, 1922). On the interpretation

pertaining to ″ ini t iat ion″ in the game of Dionysus, see Andrew Lang, Custom and Myth (1885; reprint Ooserhout, 1970), pp. 29-44, esp. pp. 39-41; and R. Pettazzoni, I misteri: Saggio di una teoria storico-religiosa (Bologna, 1924). On the ludus mundi, by Karl Jaspers in particular, see D. L. Mil ler, Gods and Games (New York, 1973), pp. 163-64. O n interpretation of fragment 52 by Heraclitus from Nietzsche to Heidegger, see G. Penzo, II nichilismo da Nietzsche a Sartre (Rome, 1976).

38. La Forme et l'Intelligible, pp. 31-64.

39. On the biography of Brother F. Colonna, see M. T. Casella and G. Pozzi, Francesco Colonna: Biografia e Opere, (Padua, 1959).

40. See the edition by G. Pozzi and L. A. Ciapponi, Hypnerotomachia Polifili

(Padua, 1964).
41. In 1463, Ficino, at thir ty, translated the Pimander attributed to Hermes

Trismegistus. Despite his precocity, his reputation d id not reach Treviso f rom Florence before 1467.

42. Yates, pp. 123-24.
43. See Hypnérotomachie, ed. Guégan-Kerver, p. 309.



44. See my discussion of J. Flamant′ s thesis, Macrobe et le néo-platonisme latin, à
la fin du IVe siècle (Leiden, 1977) in "Ordine e disordine delle sfere" (cf. also my
review of Flamands book in Aevum, 1979). Two other passages from Ficino's work relate to the doctrine of the descent of the soul among the planetary spheres and the acquisition of vehicles. In his Theologia platónica (XVIII, 4-5), Ficino mentions three vehicles of the soul (celestial, aerial, and material), which

seems to refer to Synesius of Cyrene's distinction between a vehiculum divinioris animae, which is ethereal, and a material vehicle, common to animals and to man (cf. my Magia spirituale, note 103). Proclus also makes this distinction (see my ‚Ordine e disordine delle sfere").

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Saturn by means of
the Saturnian Demons. The power of the
government and
empire is strengthened by Jupiter
through the ministry of the
Jovian Demons; similarly, Mars through
the Martians fosters
the soul's courage. The Sun, w i th the
help of the Solar De-



FIGURE 4. The ithyphallic god Pan. From
Francesco Colonna, Discours du Songe
de Poliphile [Hypnerotomachia] (Paris,
1554). Courtesy of the Wing Foundation,
The Newberry Library, Chicago.



mons, fosters the clarity of the senses
and opinions that makes
divination possible; Venus, through the
Venereans, incites
Love. Mercury, through the Mercurials,
awakens the capacity
for interpretation and expression.
Finally, the Moon, through

the lunar demons, increases procreation. (Amore, VI, 4)

Except for the idea that the planets exert their respective influences on the soul and the human body through the intermediacy of demons, this passage f rom Ficino is inspired by the Commentary on the Dream of Scipio by the Latin Neoplatonist Macrobius, who must have had as his source a treatise by Porphyry.4 4 Macrobius′s work had been circulated in the Middle Ages, and it is possible that Ficino was acquainted w i th a commentary attributed to Wil l iam of Conches, one of whose fourteenth-century manuscripts is in the National Library in Florence.45 The author of Philosophia mundi, in dealing w i t h procreation, divided the womb into seven compartments retaining sperm in which ″the human form is imprinted like a coin.4 -It is very likely that the seven divisions corre 6″ spond to the planets, whose influence on the development of the

embryo wou ld thus have been prepared in
advance through divine
wisdom permeating nature.

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,Ordine e disordine delle sfere").
Ficino does not hold this position
invariably"
since in his commentary on Plotinus's
Enneads (II, 6) we find this passage,
akin
to Proclus, Macrobius and Servius: Ex
eorum iterum animabus in nostris animis
a
Saturno contemplatio cautioque et
conservatio diligens augetur, ab Jove
civilis et prudens
potissimum gubernatio, a Marte
magnanimitas malorum iniuriarumque
expultrix, a
Mercurio inquisitio quaelibet et
expressio, a Venere charitas et
humanitas, a Sole hon-
estatis cura pudorque et gloriae studium
verioris, a Luna denique rerum vitae
necessariam
cura et providentia diligens (Opera, II,
p. 1619). The neo-Plotinian term
"vehicle"
does not appear here, nor do the
planetary demons who appear in the text
of the

Commentary to the Symposium. It is very characteristic that, in the eighteenth book of his Theologia platónica, Ficino says he does not believe in the doctrine of the soul's passage through the spheres, which he calls "a phantasy of the Platonists." Since he sets it forth in his commentaries on Enneads and Symposium, however, it is very likely he does subscribe to this theory. Stranger yet, he does not even mention it where it deserves a place of honor, that is, in the book De vita coelitus comparanda. Actually, no theoretical justification for astrological magic is as simple as the idea that, in the course of its descent, the soul is enveloped in astral tunics that respond to the momentary influences of the planets.

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sity Press, 1980.
Yates, Frances Amelia. The Art of Memory. Chicago: University of Chicago Press,

1966.
. Astraea: The Imperial Theme in the Sixteenth Century. London: Routledge &

Kegan Paul, 1975.
. The Occult Philosophy in the Elizabethan Age. London: Routledge & Kegan

Paul, 1979.
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1972.

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real truths, which are engraved in the soul in order that discursive reasoning—an objective though impotent process—may have the means to grasp and monopolize them.

Ficino's hieroglyphics, which we shall take up later, are symbols of intelligential awareness. But Ficino's successors go much farther: they even assert that the rules of the phantasmic language that translates intelligential relationships can be represented in the form of theater, to be

meditated upon and learned by anyone who so wishes. The idea of the-
ater came from the Friulan Giulio Camillo Delminio, born around 1480, who spared no pains to see it realized. A professor at Bologna, Giulio Camillo was not a charlatan. He managed to interest Francis I in his theater and, subsidized by the king, settled in Paris in 1530. In 1532 he was in Venice where Viglius Zuichemus, who corresponded with Eras-
mus, came to see him. His letter to Erasmus mockingly describes the theater of our artist with the heavenly memory, which the humanist of Rotterdam could neither appreciate nor understand. The year 1534 found Giulio Camillo again in Paris but never able to perfect his con-
struction, a wooden structure which, according to a letter of Gilbert Cousin, Erasmus's secretary, was still at the French court in 1558. Mean-
while, he was invited in 1543 to the court of Alfonso Davalas, marquis of Vastos, the Spanish governor of Milan.

Giulio Camillo lived just long enough to arrive there, for he died in 1544.15

Giulio Camillo, a modest and unassuming man whose Latin made him the butt of Zuichemus's jokes, left us few writings. He worked on rhetoric and translated Le Idee, overo Forme della Oratione, attributed to Hermogenes of Tarsus,16 but it seems he had also studied the work of Pico della Mirandola17 and perhaps also that of the Venetian Brother Francesco Giorgi,18 which is based on Ficino. His main preoccupation was adequately to depict a cosmic model. This cosmic model certainly stems from Florentine Platonism.

Camillo set forth his schema in an obscure little treatise published in Florence in 1550, L'ldea del Teatro. His construction, which had the form of an amphitheater of seven sections, aspired to be an imago mundi in which all ideas and objects might find their appropriate place by virtue

of their planetary classification. Like any artificial system, this was doomed to be no longer understood as soon as the sets linking terrestrial phenomena to corresponding planets fell into disuse. We shall see later that they were constructed according to correlations between a planet and certain animals, plants and stones and were transmitted by tradition with inevitable changes from the very beginnings of Hellenistic astrology. For the Renaissance mind there existed still a kind of internal evi-



dence inherent in the fact that the lion, gold, and the heliotrope belonged to the solar set, but this was only evidence of a cultural kind, becoming invalid as soon as astrology began to lose credibility. Giulio Camillo's schema, as Frances Yates discerned,19 was magical.

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head-heart distinction in, 114, 135-36;
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For the Renaissance mind there existed still a kind of internal evi-



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(see below, chap. 4, sec. 3). The subject matter symbolized by the dramatic figures also came from Florentine Platonism. For example, the idea of the incorporation of the soul was represented by the image of Pasiphae and the Bull on the door of the fifth level. Pasiphae symbolized the soul attracted by the body (the Bull), a theme associated with black magic, goeteia,21 by Plotinus and also by the Church Fathers. In its descent among the planetary spheres, the soul was supposed to invest itself with an aerial quality (the pneuma) enabling it to become incarnated in the material body.22 We can readily understand that working out all the details of that plan, including not only images but also cryptic formulas, was too much for one man. Once he vanished, no one else could take his place to continue his work. At bottom, Giulio Camillo's ambition amounted to no less than to forge a figura universi,23 a cosmic form ex qua tamen beneficium ab universo sperare

videntur, through which it was hoped some profit might be obtained from the universe.

Ficino himself, who describes in detail the realization of an universi figura, was not one of those who, like Giulio Camillo, cultivated the art of oratory. This is probably why it never occurred to him that the imago mundi could have the aspect of a theater. For him, the phantasmic expression of the intelligential world did not assume forms as concrete as Camillo's dolls. On the contrary, it ought to be something mysterious, unreachable by the profane.

Egyptian hieroglyphics fulfilled those requirements wonderfully. In the first place, they had the prestige of tradition: Plato himself had spoken of them (Phaedo, 274c-75b) and Plotinus too, in his Enneads (5.8):

The Egyptian priests, in symbolizing divine mysteries, did not use small characters but whole forms of plants, trees, and

animals, for it is clear that God's system of knowledge of things does not take the form of multiple fancies [excogitatio-nem multiplicem] about the thing but sees the thing itself in its simple, stable essence.24

Ficino does not end his commentary on Plotinus with this; he continues with a reference—arbitrary, moreover—to one of the hieroglyphics of Horapollon.25

## 37 Empirical Psychology and the Deep Psychology of Eros

The treatise, Hieroglyphica, attributed to Horapol lon and "translated" into Greek by an unknown writer called Phil ip, was an attraction in Flor-ence of rather recent appearance. The codex had been discovered by Cristoforo Buondelmonti on the island of Andros and taken to Florence.

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239 Notes to Pages 91-113

corresponds to transcendental reality. Two pages later, however (p. 193), Bruno seems to refer to himself when he writes: Ego eum, qui timet a corporeis, numquam
divinis fuisse coniunctum facile crediderim; vere enim sapiens et virtuosus, cum dolorem
non sentiat, est perfecte (ut praesentis vitae conditio ferre potest) beatus, si rem rationis
oculto velis aspicere. That probably explains his indifference when

confronted by
the death sentence.

70. Cf. S. Lunais, Recherches sur la Lune, I (Leiden, 1978), pp. 122 sq.

71. Cf. F. A. Yates, Astraea: The Imperial Theme in the Sixteenth Century (London

and Boston, 1975), p. 85.

72. See my article "Inter lunam terrasque . . . Incubazione, catalessi ed estasi in

Plutarcoin G. Piccaluga (ed.), Perennitas: Studi in onore di A. Brelich (Rome,
1980), now in the volume Iter in silvis, I, pp. 53-76; Expériences de l'extase, pp.
103-17.

73. See J. Festugière, La Philosophie de l'amour de Marsile Ficin et son influence sur
la littérature française au XVIe siècle (Paris, 1941).

74. See Magendie, La Politesse mondaine et les théories de l'honnêteté en France

au
XVIIe siècle (Paris, 1925), s.a., vol.
1, p. 271; Emile Picot, Les Français
italianisants
au XVe siècle (Paris, 1906-7); E.
Bourciez, Les Moeurs polies et la
littérature de cour
sous Henri II (Paris, 1886).

75. Cf. G. Weise, Videale eroico del
Rinascimento e le sue premesse
umanistiche
(Naples, 1961), II, p. 104.

76. Ibid., pp. 52-103.
77. Ibid., p. 105.
78. Ibid., p. 49.
79. Ibid., pp. 76-77.
80. Cf. H. Champion, Histoire poétique
du XVIe siècle (Paris, 1923), I, p. 167,

quoted by G. Weise, II, p. 45. J.
Festugière attributes this phenomenon to
the
translations of courtly medieval
romances: "They were so popular that,
once
again, the Cours d'amour were
established among the entourage of

François I and
Henri II, with the code of fine manners and the whole amorous jurisprudence so dear to the ladies of the Middle Ages" (p. 3). As to G. Weise, he fails to establish
the genetic connection, though an obvious one, between Ficino's Platonism and
French love poetry in the sixteenth century.

81. Yates, Astraea, p. 52.
82. Ibid., p. 77. About a similar symbolism at the French court, see now Sheila

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infinite empyrean heaven—an idea that was, at bottom, merely traditional—see also Debus, pp. 87-88.

38. Cf. Keith Thomas, Religion and the Decline of Magic, (Harmondsworth [1971], 1978), p. 412. On John Dee in general, see Peter J. French, John Dee: The
World of an Elizabethan Magus (London, 1972).

39. Op. it., I, p. 21.
40. Ibid.; cf. De docta ignorantia, II, pp. 11-12.
41. Op. cit., I, p. 92.

42. P. Ramus, De religione Christiana, Frankfurt ed., (1577), pp. 114-15, cited by Yates, The Art of Memory, p. 237.
43. Yates, ibid., pp. 234-35.
44. Ibid., p. 237.
45. Ibid., p. 261.
46. See n. 38 above.
47. Yates, The Art of Memory, pp. 266 sq.
48. Quoted by Yates, ibid., p. 278.
49. G. Perkins Cantabrigensis, Antidicsonus (London, 1584), p. 45, quoted by Yates, pp. 274-75. Fundamentally, Perkins was more correct than Yates thinks; it is true that with respect to Peter of Ravenna an absolutely inoffensive practice is at issue (he believes the image of an old love is particularly suited to being recorded by the memory, due to its emotional charge). However, in Bruno's case the technique assumes a systematic character, as evidenced by this very

interest-
ing passage from the Sigillus sigillorum
(Op. lat., II, 2, p. 166): Excitent
ergo, quae
comitante discursu, cogitatione fortique
phantasia movent affectum, quibusque
zelantes,
contemnentes, amantes, odientes,
maerentes, gaudentes, admirantes, et ad
sensuum tru-
tinam referentes, cum zeli, contemptus,
amoris, odii, maeroris, gaudii,
admirationis et
scrutinii speciebus, cum memorandae rei
forma efficimur. Porro fortiores atque
vehemen-
tiores fortius consequentia quadam atque
vehementius imprimunt (21). Has autem si
vel
tua vel rei concipiendae natura non
adferat, industria citet affectus. In
istis enim exer-
citatio nedum ad optimos pessimosque
mores viam aperit, sed et ad
intelligentiam et
(quantum per hominem fieri potest)
omnium pro viribus eiusdem activitatem.

Confxr-
matur hoc, quod populi et gentes, quibus
promptior est libido et ira, sunt
activiores; et ex
iisdem intense odientes et amantes
apprime impios, aut si se se vertant quo
divinus eos
agat amor atque zelus, apprime
religiosos habes, ubi idem materiale
principium summam
ad virtutem pariter proximum esse atque
ad vitium potes agnoscere (22).

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Content Snippet:
Giulio Camillo, a modest and unassuming man whose Latin made
him the butt of Zuichemus's jokes, left us few writings. He worked on
rhetoric and translated Le Idee, overo Forme della Oratione, attributed to
Hermogenes of Tarsus,16 but it seems he had also studied the work of
Pico della Mirandola17 and perhaps also that of the Venetian Brother
Francesco Giorgi,18 which is based on Ficino. His main preoccupation
was adequately to depict a cosmic model.

This cosmic model certainly stems from Florentine Platonism.

Camillo set forth his schema in an obscure little treatise published in Florence in 1550, L'ldea del Teatro. His construction, which had the form of an amphitheater of seven sections, aspired to be an imago mundi in which all ideas and objects might find their appropriate place by virtue of their planetary classification. Like any artificial system, this was doomed to be no longer understood as soon as the sets linking terrestrial phenomena to corresponding planets fell into disuse. We shall see later that they were constructed according to correlations between a planet and certain animals, plants and stones and were transmitted by tradition with inevitable changes from the very beginnings of Hellenistic astrology. For the Renaissance mind there existed still a kind of internal evi-

dence inherent in the fact that the lion, gold, and the heliotrope belonged to the solar set, but this was only evidence of a cultural kind, becoming invalid as soon as astrology began to lose credibility. Giulio Camillo's schema, as Frances Yates discerned,19 was magical. He was inspired less by Pico della Mirandola's speculations20 than by Ficino's treatise De vita coelitus comparanda (see below, chap. 4, sec. 3). The subject matter symbolized by the dramatic figures also came from Florentine Platonism. For example, the idea of the incorporation of the soul was represented by the image of Pasiphae and the Bull on the door of the fifth level. Pasiphae symbolized the soul attracted by the body (the Bull), a theme associated with black magic, goeteia,21 by Plotinus and also by the Church Fathers. In its descent among the planetary spheres, the soul was supposed to invest itself with an aerial quality (the pneuma) enabling it to become incarnated in the

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amoris, odii, maeroris, gaudii, admirationis et
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tua vel rei concipiendae natura non adferat, industria citet affectus. In istis enim exer-
citatio nedum ad optimos pessimosque mores viam aperit, sed et ad intelligentiam et
(quantum per hominem fieri potest) omnium pro viribus eiusdem activitatem. Confxr-
matur hoc, quod populi et gentes, quibus promptior est libido et ira, sunt activiores; et ex
iisdem intense odientes et amantes apprime impios, aut si se se vertant quo divinus eos
agat amor atque zelus, apprime religiosos habes, ubi idem materiale principium summam
ad virtutem pariter proximum esse atque

ad vitium potes agnoscere (22). Hunc amorem
omnium affectuum, studiorum et affectuum parentem (qui proxime allata causa geminus
est) daemonem magnum appellavit antiquitas, quem si tibi affabre consiliaveris, omni



procul dubio nil tibi supererit difficile. Itaque, prout expedit, explicavimus, unde quasi
per artem non solum rerum memoriam, sed et veritatem atque sapientiam per universum
humanam possis assequi (23). Bruno does not deny that emotions open the way toward the noblest as well as the most perverse customs; nevertheless, he is of the opinion that all emotions—including those which might be considered negative or immoral—are favorable to mnemotechnics.

50. P.-H. Michel, quoting Sellers, is certain that John Charlewood was the printer. See the foreword to Giordano

Bruno, Des fureurs héroïques (Paris, 1954), p. 8.

51. Yates, The Art of Memory, p. 284.

52. Ascl., IX; cf. Ficino, Op., II, p. 1865; Bruno, Op. it., II, p. 180.

53. Op. lat., II, 2, p. 133; in its entirety, the passage reads: Primus praecipuusque

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70-84. A scholar unequaled in the field of German occultism, Peuckert is the most valuable source of a list of references on Trithemius; but he does not seem
to have closely studied interpretations of the Steganography. N. L. Brann's book,
The Abbot Trithemius, 1462-1516 (Leiden, 1981), only deals w i th the monk's career.

45. Peuckert, Pansophie, pp. 72-73.
46. Georg Wil l in, Dissertatio

historico-literaria de arte Trithemiana scribendi per

ignem (Uppsala, 1728), p. 33, quoted by Klaus Arnold, Johannes Trithemius, p. 180.

47. Kur t Baschwitz, Hexen und Hexenprozesse: Die Geschichte eines Massenwahns
und seiner Bekämpfung (Munich, 1963), pp. 17 sq.

48. See Peuckert, pp. 72-73.



49. Ibid., p. 77.
50. Fama confraternitatis, in Yates, The Rosicrucian Enlightenment.
51. Primo Poeta celeberrimus . . . Secundo . . . Orator facundissimus . . . Ter-

tio . . . subtilissimus Philosophus . . . Quarto . . . Mathematicus . . . ingeniosis-
simus . . . Quinto . . . Historicus perfectus . . . Sexto . . . Theologus insignis

(Heidel, Vita Johannes Trithemius Abb., pp. 34-35).

52. The city of Würzburg, where tradition concerning Trithemius lasted about two centuries, and the monastery of Sponheim are located near Heidelberg in the Palatinate, where the ″farce″ (ludibrium) of the Rosicrucians took place at the beginning of the seventeenth century. With respect to the ″inextinguishable lamps″ found in the tomb of Father Christian Rosenkreuz, it is probable that the authors of the Fama confraternitatis made use of an element of Trithemius′ s leg-end, according to information given by Bartholomeus Korndorff derived from Servatius Hochel.

53. Trithemius's complete bibliography is recorded by Klaus Arnold, pp. 228 sq.

54. Peuckert, p. 75.

55. Heidel, Vita Johan. Trith. Abb., p.

1.

56. Arnold, p. 7.

57. Hans Ankwicz-Kleehoven, Der wiener Humanist Johannes Cuspinian, Graz-Köln, 1959, p. 16, quoted by Arnold, p. 56.

58. Arnold, p. 62.

59. Cited by Arnold, p. 61.

60. Ibid., m<58.

61. Antipmus, I, 3; Peuckert furnishes a list which is almost complete, Pansophie, pp. 47-55.

62. The text of this letter is reproduced by Heidel, pp. 50-51; it is partially

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(ii) The Art of Memory

The Ar t of Memory, also a phantasmic process whose principles and history Paolo Rossi and Frances Yates have dealt w i th in their excellent books, forms an intermediary l ink between Eros and magic. It concerns us here only to the extent that, wi thout a general idea of it, we would be at a loss to understand the ideological scope of Ficino and other theoreti-cians of phantasmic love such as Francesco Colonna and Giordano Bruno.8

The Ar t of Memory is a technique for the manipulat ion of phantasms, which rests on the Aristotelian principle of the absolute precedence of the phantasm over speech and of the phantasmic essence of the intellect (see above, chap. 1, sec. 1). The precise inference drawn from it, ex-



pounded by St. Thomas in his commentary on Aristotle's De memoria et reminiscentia, is that whatever is seen, thanks to its intrinsic quality of image, is easy to remember, whereas abstract concepts or linguistic se-quences require some phantasmic support or other to charge the memo-ry.9 This is why St. Thomas recommends recourse to the mnemotechni-cal rules contained in Ad Herennium, wrongly attributed to Cicero and also called Rhetorica secunda.

It is certain that the Art of Memory had been utilized in the Middle Ages in cloisters to foster teaching of

abstract concepts but also as a very important element of the monk's inner discipline. In the fourteenth century, two treatises in Vulgar Italian deal with it, and even Petrarch was acquainted with its rules.10

But times change, and, with the discovery in 1416 of Quintilian's Institute oratoria (which, by the way, does not endorse mnemotechnics), the humanists place the arts and virtues of the ancients on a pedestal. Whereas the Middle Ages utilized the pseudo-Ciceronian treatise ad maiorem gloriam Dei, the better to bring to mind the majestic structure of theological concepts, humanism sees in the Ars memoriae an important weapon for social success, to ensure, by means of an infallible memory, advantage over others.11 It is along these lines that the jurist Peter of Ravenna's treatise Phoenix, sive artificiosa memoria (Venice, 1491) was written.

The reader of Rossi's or Yates's books doubtless recalls the function of Art, which we shall try to reconstruct freely here without going into detail. Owing to the fact that perceptions have an intrinsically phantasmic character, and are thus readily committed to memory, the task is to superimpose any contents linguistic or conceptual—for instance a poem or classification of virtues—onto a succession of images. Now, those images can come from some place, but this does not prevent them from being, as well, phantasms produced for the circumstances by the imaginative faculty. In the first instance, the place must be chosen with care: truly, this Art demands a total concentration only possible in solitude. It follows that mnemonic activity can only be pursued in a church, a cemetery, a deserted palace, or at home, avoiding all company and diversion. The parts of the place must be memorized in a certain order.

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ing to Yates, p. 119.
15. Yates, pp. 130 sq.
16. Published at Udine in 1594; cf. D. P. Walker, Spiritual and Demonic Magic from Ficino to Campanella (London, 1958), p. 141.
17. That is Yates's opinion, p. 136.
18. Francisci Georgii Veneti Minoritae Familiae, De Harmonia Mundi Totius Cantica Tria (Venice, 1525).

19. Yates, p. 155.
20. Ibid., p. 136.

21. Cf. J. Flamant, Macrobe (Leiden, 1977), pp. 544 sq.
22. Giulio Camillo, ″LTdea del Teatro,″ in lutte le opere (Florence, 1550), p. 67; cf. Yates, p. 140.
23. Ficino, Vita coeL, chap. 19.
24. Opera, II, p. 1768.
25. Cf. E. Gombrich, ″Icônes Symbolicae,″ in Symbolic Images: Studies in the Art of the Renaissance II (Oxford, 1978), p. 222, no. 82, and pp. 158-59.
26. Cf. E. Iversen, The Myth of Egypt and its Hieroglyphs in European Tradition (Copenhagen, 1961).
27. E. Garin, Storia della filosofia italiana, vol. 1 (Turin, 1966), p. 383.
28. Comp, in Timeaum, p. 27, in A. Chastel, Marsile Ficin et l'Art (Geneva, 1954), p. 105, no. 5.
29. Theol. Plat., XV, 13; see also Garin, pp. 401-2. The tradit ion of this ″ inner

eye″ comes from Plotinus, Enneads, I, 6, 9. For Ficino, this is a phantasmic organ
directed toward the summit (the intelligible world).

30. P. O. Kristeller, Il pensiero filosofico di Marsilio Ficino, Italian translation
revised and augmented (Florence, 1953), pp. 218 sq.

31. See Verbeke, pp. 498-507.
32. For the history of the oculus spiritalis, see H. Lewy, Chaldaean Oracles and

Theurgy: Mysticism, Magic and Platonism in the Later Roman Empire (Cairo, 1956; repr. Paris, 1978, through the good offices of M. Tardieu), pp. 370 sq.

33. Chastel, Marcile Ficin et l'Art, p. 147.
34. Prooem. in Platonis Parmenidem (Opera, II, p. 1137). This is simply the Lat in

translation of an expression Xenophon had used to designate the Socratic meth-

od (paizein spoude). O n the custom of the ″serious games″ of Ficino and his contemporaries, see Edgar Wind, Pagan Mysteries in the Renaissance 3d ed. (Oxford, 1980), pp. 236-38.

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**ASSISTANT**

Ioan P. Couliano engages with mainly in relation to her work on memory, Renaissance magic, and her interpretations of figures like Giordano Bruno and Giulio Camillo. He acknowledges Yates's "undeniable merit" in placing thinkers like Bruno within their intellectual contexts, rehabilitating them from caricature as merely eccentric precursors of modernity【8:2†Ioan P. Couliano Eros and Magic in the Renaissance Chicago Original Paperback.pdf】. However, Couliano is critical of her tendency to lump diverse Late Antique doctrines under the umbrella of "Hermeticism" indiscriminately【8:2†Ioan P. Couliano Eros and Magic in the Renaissance Chicago Original Paperback.pdf】.

Couliano also comments on , noting her insight that Camillo’s memory theater was "magical" rather than purely mnemonic. Couliano nuances this by tracing Camillo’s system more directly to influence

rather than Pico's, emphasizing its Florentine Platonic roots【8:11†Ioan P. Couliano Eros and Magic in the Renaissance Chicago Original Paperback.pdf】. He also agrees with Yates that Camillo's endeavor to create an imago mundi through a theater of memory was inherently unstable once the cultural connections to astrology and planetary correspondences faded【8:11†Ioan P. Couliano Eros and Magic in the Renaissance Chicago Original Paperback.pdf】.

On , Couliano presents it as a unique literary case of "phantasmic Eros." He distinguishes Colonna's work from the Ficinian tradition, emphasizing its independence from Ficino’s influence despite its alignment with broader Renaissance concerns about images, desire, and allegory【8:1†Ioan P. Couliano Eros and Magic in the Renaissance Chicago Original Paperback.pdf】. Couliano reads the *Hypnerotomachia* as a narrative about

phantasms that blends allegory and empirical psychology—a story where erotic desire is both provoked and satisfied by phantasmic images. He finds its labyrinthine structure notable, with a first part dense with allegorical imagery and a second part that explains the dreamlike plot, underscoring its exploration of the interplay between erotic desire and memory 【8:3†Ioan P. Couliano Eros and Magic in the Renaissance Chicago Original Paperback.pdf】.

Finally, Couliano echoes that the imagery in the *Hypnerotomachia* might be a case of mnemonic technique spun out into fantastical elaboration, though he distances his own analysis from dwelling on that dimension 【8:3†Ioan P. Couliano Eros and Magic in the Renaissance Chicago Original Paperback.pdf】.

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give me a more detailed discussion of everything he has to say about HP

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tasms without physical support of one kind or another. That is why a story about phantasms is always interpretable: we can see it either as the symbol of adventures in the intelligential cosmos or as the allegory of actual events.

Unfortunately, although there are many theoreticians of phantasmic Eros, the number of writers who have tried to describe phantasms at work is very limited. One of them surely

is the respectable monk from Treviso, Francesco Colonna, who, having become sacristan of the monastery of St. John and St. Paul in Padua, died in 1527 at the age of ninety-four.39 He is the author of a work almost unique of its kind, the Hypnerotomachia Poliphili, which, as the author points out in the book's explicit, had been finished May 1, 1467, but was not published until 1499 by Aldo Manuzio; it was paid for by a magistrate of Verona, called Leonardo Crasso.40

The contents of the Hypnerotomachia tally with the date 1467. Indeed, the work is external to the current of ideas circulated by Marsilio Ficino



FIGURE 3. "Two wretched damsels, naked and disheveled." From Francesco Colonna, Discours du Songe de Poliphile [Hypnerotomachia] (Paris, 1554). Courtesy

of the Wing Foundation, The Newberry Library, Chicago.

beginning more or less in 1463.41 From our point of v iew, the fact that i t escapes Ficino's influence is invaluable. Even when expressing a person-
al point of v iew on love, wh ich rarely happens, Pico della Mirandola, Pietro Bembo, Baldesar Castiglione, Leo the Hebrew, and Melanchthon bear the indelible mark of Ficino's thought. O n the contrary, Colonna (though he, too, treats of the phantasmic Eros) is original and inimitable,
less in his ideas—a common heritage of the period, of wh ich Ficino is to become the systematic organizer—than in the l i terary and didactic quali-
ty of his work.

(iv) Phantasms at Work

Let us make the acquaintance of phantasms.
Taken literally, the title

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The tale is not constructed so as to be easily understood. It is an enigma



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Poliphilus seeks Polia, but does not know w h y or how. Of the 311 pages
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monologues, is therefore a tale within a tale,
and the end is destined to complicate the enigma still more: we learn that everything that happened was only Poliphilus's dream, so that the search for Polia and the appeasement of desire were but adventures in phantasy.43

Neither mystical love nor vulgar love, Poliphilus's dream represents the trite story of phantasmic desire that finds fulf i l lment.

The tale is saved f rom platitude and indecency by its phantasmic quality: desire, provoked by a phantasm, is appeased by the phantasm, after a period of erotico-mnemotechnic tribulations.

(v) The Depth Psychology of Ficino

D E S C E N T OF T H E SOUL

Souls descend into the bodies of the Mi lky Way through the constellation of Cancer, enveloping themselves in a celestial and luminous veil which they put on to

enter terrestrial
bodies. For nature demands that the very
pure soul be united
w i th the very impure body only through
the intermediary of a
pure veil, which, being less pure than
the soul and purer than
the body, is considered by the
Platonists to be a very conve-
nient means of uni t ing the soul w i th
the terrestrial body. It is
due to that descent that the souls and
bodies of the Planets
confirm and reinforce, i n our Souls and
our bodies respec-
tively, the seven original gifts
bestowed upon us by God. The
same function is performed by the
[seven] categories of de-
mons, intermediaries between the
celestial gods and men. The
gift of contemplation is strengthened by
Saturn by means of
the Saturnian Demons.

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For all parties, the prel iminaries of desire consist i n setting u p a phantasm w i t h i n the subject. For some,
this phantasm w i l l have the capacity to awaken their allayed desire, to propel and accompany them on their t r ip th rough the intel l igential cos-
mos. This w i l l become a heroic passion ending in an ecstatic fusion of the hunter and the object of his hunt—
accord ing to an image employed
by Ficino and later revived by Giordano Bruno. For others, the phan-

tasm w i l l only point to a painfu l
and urgent need for a physical release
which increases in propor t ion as its
fu l f i l lment is postponed.

In this case there w i l l be a
fundamental contradict ion between the
medical concept of a phantasmic Eros
that disturbs the equi l ibr ium of
the organism and demands p rompt
assuagement to restore this equi-
l ibr ium, and the concept of the " fa i
th fu l , -a complete denial of the for
"
mer, f ind ing expression through a
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Saturn by means of
the Saturnian Demons. The power of the
government and
empire is strengthened by Jupiter
through the ministry of the
Jovian Demons; similarly, Mars through
the Martians fosters
the soul's courage. The Sun, w i th the
help of the Solar De-



FIGURE 4. The ithyphallic god Pan. From
Francesco Colonna, Discours du Songe
de Poliphile [Hypnerotomachia] (Paris,
1554). Courtesy of the Wing Foundation,
The Newberry Library, Chicago.



mons, fosters the clarity of the senses
and opinions that makes
divination possible; Venus, through the
Venereans, incites
Love. Mercury, through the Mercurials,
awakens the capacity
for interpretation and expression.
Finally, the Moon, through

the lunar demons, increases procreation. (Amore, VI, 4)

Except for the idea that the planets exert their respective influences on the soul and the human body through the intermediacy of demons, this passage f rom Ficino is inspired by the Commentary on the Dream of Scipio by the Latin Neoplatonist Macrobius, who must have had as his source a treatise by Porphyry.4 4 Macrobius′s work had been circulated in the Middle Ages, and it is possible that Ficino was acquainted w i th a commentary attributed to Wil l iam of Conches, one of whose fourteenth-century manuscripts is in the National Library in Florence.45 The author of Philosophia mundi, in dealing w i t h procreation, divided the womb into seven compartments retaining sperm in which ″the human form is imprinted like a coin.4 -It is very likely that the seven divisions corre 6″ spond to the planets, whose influence on the development of the

embryo wou ld thus have been prepared in
advance through divine
wisdom permeating nature.

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Ficino does not hold this position
invariably"
since in his commentary on Plotinus's
Enneads (II, 6) we find this passage,
akin
to Proclus, Macrobius and Servius: Ex
eorum iterum animabus in nostris animis
a
Saturno contemplatio cautioque et
conservatio diligens augetur, ab Jove
civilis et prudens
potissimum gubernatio, a Marte
magnanimitas malorum iniuriarumque
expultrix, a
Mercurio inquisitio quaelibet et
expressio, a Venere charitas et
humanitas, a Sole hon-
estatis cura pudorque et gloriae studium
verioris, a Luna denique rerum vitae
necessariam
cura et providentia diligens (Opera, II,
p. 1619). The neo-Plotinian term
"vehicle"
does not appear here, nor do the
planetary demons who appear in the text
of the

Commentary to the Symposium. It is very characteristic that, in the eighteenth book of his Theologia platónica, Ficino says he does not believe in the doctrine of the soul's passage through the spheres, which he calls "a phantasy of the Platonists." Since he sets it forth in his commentaries on Enneads and Symposium, however, it is very likely he does subscribe to this theory. Stranger yet, he does not even mention it where it deserves a place of honor, that is, in the book De vita coelitus comparanda. Actually, no theoretical justification for astrological magic is as simple as the idea that, in the course of its descent, the soul is enveloped in astral tunics that respond to the momentary influences of the planets.

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1954), p. 105, no. 5.
29. Theol. Plat., XV, 13; see also Garin, pp. 401-2. The tradit ion of this ″ inner

eye″ comes from Plotinus, Enneads, I, 6, 9. For Ficino, this is a phantasmic organ
directed toward the summit (the intelligible world).

30. P. O. Kristeller, Il pensiero filosofico di Marsilio Ficino, Italian translation
revised and augmented (Florence, 1953), pp. 218 sq.

31. See Verbeke, pp. 498-507.

32. For the history of the oculus spiritalis, see H. Lewy, Chaldaean Oracles and

Theurgy: Mysticism, Magic and Platonism in the Later Roman Empire (Cairo, 1956; repr. Paris, 1978, through the good offices of M. Tardieu), pp. 370 sq.

33. Chastel, Marcile Ficin et l'Art, p. 147.

34. Prooem. in Platonis Parmenidem (Opera, II, p. 1137). This is simply the Lat in

translation of an expression Xenophon had used to designate the Socratic method (paizein spoude). O n the custom of the "serious games" of Ficino and his contemporaries, see Edgar Wind, Pagan Mysteries in the Renaissance 3d ed. (Oxford, 1980), pp. 236-38.

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(ii) The Art of Memory

The Ar t of Memory, also a phantasmic process whose principles and history Paolo Rossi and Frances Yates have dealt w i th in their excellent books, forms an intermediary l ink between Eros and magic. It concerns us here only to the extent that, wi thout a general idea of it, we would be at a loss to understand the ideological scope of Ficino and other theoreti-cians of phantasmic love such as Francesco Colonna and Giordano Bruno.8

The Ar t of Memory is a technique for the manipulat ion of phantasms, which rests on the Aristotelian principle of the absolute precedence of the phantasm over speech and of the phantasmic essence of the intellect (see above, chap. 1, sec. 1). The precise inference drawn from it, ex-



pounded by St. Thomas in his commentary on Aristotle's De memoria et reminiscentia, is that whatever is seen, thanks to its intrinsic quality of image, is easy to remember, whereas abstract concepts or linguistic se-quences require some phantasmic support or other to charge the memo-ry.9 This is why St. Thomas recommends recourse to the mnemotechni-cal rules contained in Ad Herennium, wrongly attributed to Cicero and also called Rhetorica secunda.

It is certain that the Art of Memory had been utilized in the Middle Ages in cloisters to foster teaching of

abstract concepts but also as a very important element of the monk's inner discipline. In the fourteenth century, two treatises in Vulgar Italian deal with it, and even Petrarch was acquainted with its rules.10

But times change, and, with the discovery in 1416 of Quintilian's Institute oratoria (which, by the way, does not endorse mnemotechnics), the humanists place the arts and virtues of the ancients on a pedestal. Whereas the Middle Ages utilized the pseudo-Ciceronian treatise ad maiorem gloriam Dei, the better to bring to mind the majestic structure of theological concepts, humanism sees in the Ars memoriae an important weapon for social success, to ensure, by means of an infallible memory, advantage over others.11 It is along these lines that the jurist Peter of Ravenna's treatise Phoenix, sive artificiosa memoria (Venice, 1491) was written.

The reader of Rossi's or Yates's books doubtless recalls the function of Art, which we shall try to reconstruct freely here without going into detail. Owing to the fact that perceptions have an intrinsically phantasmic character, and are thus readily committed to memory, the task is to superimpose any contents linguistic or conceptual—for instance a poem or classification of virtues—onto a succession of images. Now, those images can come from some place, but this does not prevent them from being, as well, phantasms produced for the circumstances by the imaginative faculty. In the first instance, the place must be chosen with care: truly, this Art demands a total concentration only possible in solitude. It follows that mnemonic activity can only be pursued in a church, a cemetery, a deserted palace, or at home, avoiding all company and diversion. The parts of the place must be memorized in a certain order.

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″
interpretable as a phantasmic process, a visio spiritalis in the August inian sense.31 It is, in fact, a need to discover a means of communication be-
tween reason and intellect (the soul), and this means is provided by the spiritual eye, the mysterious organ that permits us to look upward to-
ward the higher ontological levels.32

André Chastel believes that the term hieroglypha, as used by Ficino, does not refer to a form communicated by the soul to the faculty of

reason through the intermediary of the pneuma. Rather, it is a symbol of meditation ″keeping the spirit in a state of tension propitious to a k ind of meditation close to ecstasy, the talisman of the oculus mentis.33″

Pseudo-Egyptian hieroglyphics, emblems, and impresae were wonder-
fully suited to the playful spirit of Florentine Platonism, to the myste-
rious and ″myst i fy ing″ quality Ficino believed it had. ″Pythagoras,



Socrates, and Plato had the habit of h id ing all divine mysteries behind the veil of figurative language to protect their wisdom modestly from the Sophists′ boastfulness, of joking seriously and playing assiduously, iocari serio et studiosissime ludere."34 That famous turn of phrase of Ficino's—translation of a remark by Xenophon concerning the Socratic method—depicts, at bottom, the quintessence of every phantasmic pro-
cess, whether it be Eros, the Ar t of

Memory, magic, or alchemy—the ludus puerorum, preeminently a game for children. What, indeed, are we doing in any of the above if not playing with phantasms, trying to keep up with their game, which the benevolent unconscious sets up for us? Now, it is not easy to play a game whose rules are not known ahead of time. We must apply ourselves seriously, assiduously, to try to understand and learn them so that the disclosures made to us may not remain un-answered by us.

In the Ball Game (De ludo globi, 1463) by Nicholas of Cusa, these verses have been inserted although they do not belong to the author:35

Luditur hie ludus; sed non pueriliter, at sic
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Dionysus play in order to seize h im and put h im to death.36 From the ashes of the Titans struck down by the l ightning of Zeus, arose man-k ind, a race guil ty wi thout having sinned because of the deicide of its ancestors. But, since the Titans had incorporated part of the god, men also inherited a spark f rom the murdered child, the divine child whose game is the metaphor of the ages: "A ion is a child who plays checkers: the sovereignty of a chi ld!37"

(iii) The Phantasmic Eros and the Appeasement of Desire

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The case of Pico della Mirandola, which we shall analyze in chapter 3, is more complicated: it wou ld be called a striking example of the Oedipus complex if that term had not fallen into disuse through repeated abuse. Stimulated, or rather irritated, by Ficino′s little masterpiece on love, Pico abandons all courtesy and tries to refute it in toto. That is why he attacks Guido Cavalcanti for lacking profundity and holds up as a model for a love poem a canzona by his own fr iend Girolamo Benivieni on which he undertakes a commentary. The example of Pico is highly significant. The young man forgets what elsewhere he reveals he knows only too well , in particular that a cultural era is not defined by the content of the ideas it conveys but by its interpretive filter. It demands of Guido Cavalcanti that which Ficino, more subtle in this respect, would

never have asked: to wit, that he already use the Platonistic interpretation of the fifteenth century! Benivieni's Canzona only differs from a canzona by Cavalcanti in that it furnishes directly to Pico della Mirandola the interpretation he would have made even in the absence of the poem because it was his own interpretation of Eros in general. The Platonistic reading of Cavalcanti signified, to Ficino, a hermeneutic bias which also allowed him to pay tribute to a precursor and to the ancestor of someone he liked. Now, in rejecting a real object for interpretation—because the difference between his commentary and the text commentated is only prosodie, the former being in prose, the latter in verse—Pico peremptorily rejects all hermeneutics. For Ficino, Cavalcanti exists to the extent he said something interpretable; for Pico, he does not exist since he does

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Whether expressed in a polite or positive way, as by Ficino, or in the contemptuous and negative manner of Pico, it is certain that the Florentine Renaissance takes chronological precedence over the rediscovery of the other Renaissance, that of the twelfth and thirteenth centuries.

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Content Snippet:
Circulating through the same pneumatic passage in which contagion
of the blood is spread are images that, in the mirror of common sense,

31 Empirical Psychology and the Deep Psychology of Eros

are changed into phantasms. When Eros is at work, the phantasm of
the loved object leads its own
existence, all the more disquieting be-
cause it exerts a k ind of vampir ism on
the subject's other phantasms
and thoughts. It is a morbid distension
of its activity which, in its re-

sults, can be called both concentration and possession: concentration, because the subject's entire inner life is reduced to contemplation of one phantasm only; possession, because this phantasmic monopoly is involuntary and its collateral influence over the subject's psychosomatic condition is highly deleterious.

Interestingly, the love object plays a secondary role i n the process of establishing the phantasm: it is only a pretext, not a real presence. The true object, omnipresent, of Eros is the phantasm, which has taken permanent possession of the spiritual mirror. Now, this phantasm represents a perceived image that has gone beyond the threshold of consciousness, but the reason it has assumed such obsessional dimensions lies in the deepest part of the individual unconscious. We do not love another object, a stranger to ourselves, Ficino thinks (Amore, VI, 6), thus anticipating the analytic psychology of Carl

Jung. We are enamored of an
unconscious image.

,The lover carves into his soul the
model of the beloved. In that way″
the soul of the lover becomes the mirror
in which the image of the loved
one is reflected": Amans amati
suofiguram sculpit in animo. Fit itaque
aman-
tis animus speculum in quo amati relucet
imago (ibid., II, 8). That entails
rather a complicated dialectic of love,
in which the object is changed into
the subject ousting the subject who,
tormented by the anxiety of pro-
spective annihilation due to being
deprived of his state as subject, des-
perately claims the right to a form of
existence.

The phantasm that monopolizes the soul
is the image of an object.
Now, since man is soul, and since soul
is totally occupied by a phan-
tasm, the phantasm is henceforth the
soul. It fol lows that the subject,
bereft of his soul, is no longer a

subject: the phantasmic vampire has devoured it internally. But it also follows that the subject has now grafted itself onto the phantasm which is the image of the other, of the beloved. Metaphorically, therefore, it can be said that the subject has been changed into the object of his love.

A strange situation wi thout a conclusion if it continues thus: a person
without a soul decays and dies (Ficino's subtlety does not go so far as to imagine what happens to that soul after death; he only avers that the beloved exists in duplicate and the lover no longer in any form). A solu-tion does exist, however: that the beloved accept, in his turn, the offer of
love. In this case he w i l l also allow the phantasm of the lover to enter

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(iii) The Phantasmic Eros and the Appeasement of Desire

Wherever Eros is at issue, so is desire. Where desire is at issue, so is its appeasement.

That applies to Dr. Freud as much as to the theoreticians of love in the Middle Ages and the Renaissance, w i t h one exception: the latter, sometimes revealing amazing knowledge through their freedom and candor w i t h regard to human sexuality, nevertheless grant the existence of other forms of satisfaction of desire. Indeed, Eros, being by nature spiritual, hence located at an intermediate level between the soul and the body, the intelligential wor ld and the sensory wor ld, it can lean toward one or the other of those cosmic regions. But, given that desire is the



pursuit of a phantasm and that the phantasm itself belongs to a wor ld , the imaginary wo r l d—the mundus imaginalis whose loftiness Henry Corb in has so wel l described w i thou t

dealing w i t h its penumbra—there is also a th i rd possibil i ty, namely that Eros burns away altogether in a phantasmic sphere.

The spir i tual Eros funct ion ing anagogically: that is what Dante propounds, as R. Kle in has so we l l demonstrated;38 the natural love that descends to the body: that is the experience of many wri ters of the school of Boccaccio, rediscovered in Freudian psychoanalysis w i t h the stubborn intent of reducing to a single factor the mul t i tud inous manifestations of Eros. I t goes w i thou t saying that those two tradit ions have one point i n common: the recognit ion, i f not of the nature of Eros, at least of its phantasmic techniques.

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13 History of Phantasy

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Modern scholars, who sometimes confuse the rediscovery with the summarizing or literal resumption of the same ideas, accord such precedence only to Mario Equicola, interpreter of Provençal poetry in his Libro de natura de amore, of which the Latin original—on which the Italian translation of 1509-11 (published in 1525) was based—dates back to the years 1494-96,27 right after the death of Pico. Now, it is true that Mario Equicola refers directly to the lyric style of the troubadours, whereas Cavalcanti, in whom Ficino discovers a precursor, is only the later representative of an Italian school, which, also profiting from the lessons of the Sicilian school28 and in competition

with the school of Bologna, re-
places the code of the troubadours with
one that is more rigid and ″sci-
entific." Of course, the two examples
are not superimposable, but
stilnovism" and Provençal poetry both
stem from the same existential″
root of courtly love.

ACCULTURATION OF THE WEST

The observer of ideas and currents
taking place on the twelfth-century
stage is frustrated by their variety. A
quick foray into the wings, which
few have yet dared to attempt, shows us
that many strings are held in
the same hand, the same ″selective w i l
l , " perhaps.29

The phenomenon that characterizes the
movements of ideas in the

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i f not of the nature of Eros, at least of its phantasmic techniques. For all parties, the prel iminaries of desire consist i n setting u p a phantasm w i t h i n the subject. For some,
this phantasm w i l l have the capacity to awaken their allayed desire, to propel and accompany them on their t r ip th rough the intel l igential cos-
mos. This w i l l become a heroic passion ending in an ecstatic fusion of the hunter and the object of his hunt—accord ing to an image employed
by Ficino and later revived by Giordano Bruno. For others, the phan-
tasm w i l l only point to a painfu l and urgent need for a physical release which increases in propor t ion as its fu l f i l lment is postponed.

In this case there w i l l be a fundamental contradict ion between the medical concept of a phantasmic Eros that disturbs the equi l ibr ium of the organism and demands p rompt assuagement to restore this equi-

l ibr ium, and the concept of the " fa i
th fu l , -a complete denial of the for
"
mer, f ind ing expression through a
semantic inversion valor iz ing the
disequil ibr ium in terms of a plenary
spir i tual experience. This w i l l to
distort, first brought to bear on
medical matters of the period, subse-
quently provoked much ribaldry directed
against believers i n mystical
love whose ideas, bereft of sense, are
to become synonymous w i t h an
erotic strategy in wh ich the purely
verbal idealization of woman is mere-
ly an expedient to silence her
resistance as quickly as possible.

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That sickness is precisely the experience described by Guido Caval-canti, continuing f rom the moment the visual spirit intercepts the wom-an's image and transmits it to the anterior cell of the brain, seat of the imaginative faculty, unt i l the moment the feminine phantasm has in-fested the whole pneuma and spreads f rom now on through the spir-itual canals of the febrile organism. No one w i l l be astonished that the poet Giacomo da Lentino should ask this seemingly childish question:

H o w can it be that so large a woman has been able to penetrate my eyes, which are so small, and then enter my heart and my brain?64 The physicians of antiquity, like Galen, were also fascinated by the same phenomenon: Si ergo ad visum ex re videnda aliquid dirigitur . . . quomodo ilium angustum foramen intrare poterit?65 Averroes answers the astonishment (feigned) of both parties: it is not a corporeal impression but a phantasmic one. Common sense receives the phantasms on this side of the retina and transmits them to the imaginative faculty.66

Dante goes farther in his erotic pneumophantasmology. In sonnet 21 of his Vita nova, he envisages the Lady as the recipient of spirit overflowing through eyes and mouth, miracolo gentil.67 His experience does not pine away in an interior pneumatic circle but represents, in a certain way, a decanting of spirit which takes for granted, albeit involuntari ly,

some reciprocity of desire. Through a k ind of significatio passiva,68 what was the object of covetous desire is transformed into a subject whence Love emanates, but emanates wi thout being aware of it. Virginal inno- cence that only increases the pangs of passion, the exquisite torment of love's faithful.



With his Vita nova, Dante also enters a mysterious realm that our rudi- ments of medieval psychology are inadequate to explain: dream, vision.

(iii) The Vehicle of the Soul and Prenatal Experience

That empirical psychology regarding Eros which w i l l recur in Ficino was inadequate to satisfy Renaissance demands for depth in thought. The theory of phantasmic knowing merely represented the last l ink in a huge body of dogma relating to the pneuma and the soul.

As we shall see, the connection between Eros and magic is so close that differentiation between them is a matter of degree. A phantasmic experience carried out through the spiritual channels w i th which we are already acquainted, magic makes use of the continuity between the individual pneuma and the cosmic one. It is this same universal pneumatic ,that justifies the depth psychology of Eros (see below "combination" chap. 4, sec. 2).

Through the doctrine of incorporation of the soul, not only is the con-t inuity of the pneuma demonstrated but also the cosmic nature of all spiritual activity. It is of course a rather refined form of speculation on the relations between microcosm and macrocosm, along w i th a dual projection that leads to the cosmization of man and to the anthropomorphization of the universe.

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is set forth as a systematic distortion or even a seman-
tic inversion of ideas which pass through the interpretive grille of the era.

A l l of this means that the crowning wish of the historian of ideas is

Phantasms at Work 12

not, or should not be, to define the ideological contents of a given peri-
od, which are fundamentally recursive in nature, but to glimpse its her-
meneutic filter, its ″selective w i l l

, which is, at the same time, a will to
”
distort.

A n ideology can be described; a system
of interpretation—the only
one that counts because it alone can
show what the originality of one
cultural moment in time relative to
every other is capable of—is imper-
ceptible. A n implicit if not a hidden
presence but also an objective and
ineluctible one, it is revealed
stealthily in all its complexity only to
imme-
diately escape the observation of the
investigator. In order for h im to
practice the history of ideas, he is
called upon to see not only what is
preeminently revealed, the ideas
themselves, but precisely that which is
not revealed, the hidden threads that l
ink ideas to the invisible wi l l of
the time, their producer. Ideas are seen
by everyone; the historian of
ideas is supposed to look in the wings,
to contemplate another aspect of

the theater, the stage seen from wi th in.

It is impossible to observe the Renaissance of the fifteenth century wi thout having first glanced at the Renaissance of the twelfth.24 Theo-ries about phantasmic Eros were developed in the course of the latter to reach their apogee, which soon degenerated into affectation, in the poet-
ry of the Dolce Stil Novo.

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# 13 History of Phantasy

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This time, the material used by Bruno is made up of phantasmic em-
blems whose prestige also derives f rom the hermetic statues. Are not
those spiritual constructions, in the final analysis, forms used by magic itself? It is true that their use here comes down to memorizing the stages
of Eros, but is not Eros itself an anagogic force which produces the ec-
static union of the soul w i th God?

A t first glance, De gl'heroici furori is a series of sonnets w i th commen-
tary, of the type of Dante's Vita nova.

Like Pico della Mirandola, f rom whom he borrowed many of the themes of the Commento, Bruno does not hesitate to copy certain poems which, according to F. Fiorentino, belong to Tansillo of Venosa, the main character and Bruno's spokes-man in the dialogue. But most of the sonnets are the creation of the author himself, whether they be commentaries in verse on the represen-tations of Eros or poetic expressions of the ″heroic furors."

In the Sigillus sigillorum, Bruno had already explained the deep reason for ut pictura poesis, the equivalence between painting and poetry. Zeuxis is the painter of internal images in the memory, who excels in phantastica



virtus, imaginative power. In turn, the poet possesses powers of thought out of the ordinary whose source is also spiritual. ″ I t follows that philos-ophers are also painters and poets, poets are painters and philosophers,

and painters are philosophers and poets.53″ Indeed, since intellect is phantasmic by nature, the philosopher must be able to manage phantasms, to be a great painter of the spirit. D id not Aristotle say that ″to comprehend means to observe phantasms? 54″ The place where phantasms are reflected, as we already know, is the mirror of the pneuma.

Philosophy, poetry, painting: these are the contents of De gl'heroici furori. These three stages of phantasmic speculation are so inextricably intertwined that it is impossible to separate them wi thout destroying the uni ty of the subject. Unfortunately, being incapable, since the t r iumph of rationalism, of understanding the phantasmagoric of the great artists of Memory, we shall have to make a sharp dichotomy between what is possible to grasp w i t h our mere logical, historical, and comparative methods and that which, to avoid being drawn into the revived mne-

monics, we must leave aside after a concise description.

The f i f th dialogue in part 1 is a course in the Ar t of Memory applied to intellectual processes, in fifteen chapters. The impresae symbolizing the stages of love's sophistry are explained in sonnets, which, in turn, are the subject matter of the prose commentary. To give an idea of the processes uti l ized by the painter Zeuxis, it is enough to mention the third mnemonic image appearing on the escutcheon of the "heroic furor":
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**ASSISTANT**

Couliano devotes a concentrated section of *Eros and Magic in the Renaissance* to Francesco